

Original Prompt Story

Liquid Common Sense

Chapter One: The Delivery

The first sign that something was wrong was the coffee.

It stopped moving.

Bonji noticed because the cup on the console had always rattled during acceleration. The Starlight Courier vibrated so constantly that every loose object aboard the ship had developed its own rhythm. The coffee usually trembled in tiny circles whenever the engines pushed above cruising power. Now it sat perfectly still.

Bonji stared at it for several seconds before reaching for the brass compass.

The antique compass had belonged to the original captain of the Starlight Courier, Bonji's great-grandfather, and had survived every generation of the family that had owned the ship. It hadn't accurately pointed toward anything in over a century, but Bonji polished it whenever they were worried. They were polishing it now.

"What's wrong?" KanRita asked from the navigation station.

Bonji didn't answer immediately. Their fingertips rested against the arm of the captain's chair. There it was again: a faint vibration, almost nothing, a pulse traveling through the ship's frame.

"We're being watched," Bonji finally said.

KanRita looked at the sensors. "Nothing within three hundred thousand kilometers."

"I didn't say there was something nearby."

"You said we're being watched."

"I know what I said."

KanRita turned back toward the navigation display. "Then I'll assume you're wrong until the instruments tell me otherwise."

Bonji smiled faintly. "That's why I like you."

From somewhere beneath the bridge came a metallic crash.

Then a voice shouted, "WHO TOUCHED BUSTER?"

Bonji closed their eyes.

"Never mind."

Neb Jr. the 3rd came charging through the hatch carrying a wrench. Technically, it was a wrench. Neb considered that description deeply offensive.

"Buster was sitting exactly where I left him."

KanRita glanced at the tool. "It's a wrench."

Neb stopped dead. Their expression became one of profound betrayal.

"Don't call him that."

Bonji sighed. "What's wrong with the ship?"

"Nothing."

"That wasn't my question."

Dr Stephen Buerle

Neb grinned. "I made improvements."

Bonji's smile disappeared. "What kind of improvements?"

"The kind that will eventually allow this magnificent vessel to exceed its factory-rated jump capacity by approximately four hundred percent."

"You modified the drive."

"I enhanced the drive."

"You modified the drive."

"I prefer visionary engineering."

Bonji slowly returned to polishing the compass.

"One day you're going to kill us."

Neb smiled. "Yes, but we'll get somewhere really interesting first."

KanRita ignored them both. Their eyes remained fixed on the navigation display as hundreds of stars slowly shifted across the holographic map. The Starlight Courier was approaching the outer edge of the warzone, and their destination was only three jumps away.

Three jumps between them and home.

Three jumps between their planet and the substance that could transform it from an insignificant industrial world into the most powerful civilization in known space.

Liquid Common Sense.

Nobody knew where it had come from. Nobody knew who had created it. Nobody understood why only a handful of civilizations possessed it. But everyone knew what it did.

A few milliliters could make a mediocre scientist brilliant. A politician suddenly understood the consequences of their decisions. An engineer could see solutions that had remained invisible for decades. A military strategist could recognize the shortest path through an impossible battlefield.

The richest civilizations in the galaxy didn't call it medicine.

They called it insurance.

And one small container was worth more than the Starlight Courier, its crew, and their homeworld combined.

Stivio was responsible for keeping it safe.

He had checked the container twelve times in the last hour.

He checked it again.

Temperature stable.

Pressure stable.

Seal stable.

Container mass unchanged.

"Project Grandmama's Soup is secure," he whispered.

Then he checked the lock.

Again.

And again.

And again.

Stivio wore enough padded pockets to survive a small industrial accident and refused to sit anywhere until he knew every emergency exit within twenty meters. He was halfway through memorizing the cargo bay's evacuation routes when the lights flickered.

Stivio froze.

The lights came back.

He stared at the crate.

"Please don't do that."

The ship groaned.

Then something hit the hull.

Hard.

Chapter Two: The Men Who Owned the Ship

The bridge alarms erupted.

Bonji immediately grabbed the controls. "Report."

Neb's voice came through the intercom. "That was not me."

"That's not reassuring."

"Wasn't trying to be."

KanRita scanned the tactical display. "Object approaching from aft."

"Size?"

"Small."

"Transponder?"

"None."

Bonji's hands tightened around the controls.

The ship shuddered again.

Something struck the Courier's hull.

A magnetic boarding probe.

Bonji's eyes narrowed.

"Pirates?"

KanRita shook their head.

"No."

Another vibration passed through the ship.

Bonji felt it before the sensors registered it.

Not one ship.

Several.

"How many?"

Dr Stephen Buerle

KanRita hesitated.

"Six."

The bridge went silent.

Then the comm system activated.

A calm voice filled the ship.

"Starlight Courier, this is Meridian Asset Recovery. Your vessel is in default of multiple outstanding obligations. You are hereby ordered to surrender your ship and cargo for reclamation."

Neb appeared on the bridge.

"MAR."

Bonji nodded.

Meridian Asset Recovery was the largest corporate repossession company in the galaxy. They could legally seize ships from bankrupt corporations, delinquent contractors, private owners, and entire colonies. Their paperwork was impeccable.

Their weapons were better.

"How did they find us?" Stivio asked.

Nobody answered.

A second transmission arrived.

"Failure to comply will result in asset destruction."

Bonji looked at the crew.

Dr Stephen Buerle

"Nobody panic."

Neb raised a hand.

"I've already started."

Bonji looked at KanRita.

"Can we outrun them?"

"No."

"Can we hide?"

"Not from six warships."

Bonji polished the compass.

KanRita noticed.

"You only do that when you're afraid."

Bonji stopped.

"I am not afraid."

"You've been polishing that compass for four minutes."

Bonji looked down.

The brass surface gleamed.

"...We're in trouble."

Chapter Three: Grandmama's Soup

Stivio ran.

He reached Cargo Bay Three and threw open the access panel. The crate sat exactly where he'd left it.

He checked the seals.

Still intact.

He checked the pressure.

Still stable.

He checked the temperature.

Still perfect.

Then he heard footsteps.

Stivio froze.

Someone was coming down the corridor.

He grabbed the nearest tool.

A screwdriver.

The footsteps stopped outside.

The door opened.

Dr Stephen Buerle

Neb entered.

Stivio nearly stabbed him.

"Whoa!"

"Don't sneak up on me!"

"I wasn't sneaking."

"You were walking silently."

"That's called walking."

Stivio lowered the screwdriver.

"Why are you here?"

Neb held up a small electronic device.

"I found something."

They both looked at the crate.

Neb lowered their voice.

"The MAR fleet isn't scanning the ship randomly."

Stivio's face went pale.

"They know."

"I think they know exactly what we're carrying."

Dr Stephen Buerle

Stivio immediately checked the crate.

"Impossible."

Neb nodded toward the ceiling.

"That's what I thought."

A tiny green light blinked inside the maintenance panel.

A transmitter.

Someone had been broadcasting their position.

Stivio stared at it.

"How long?"

Neb removed the device.

"Can't tell."

"Can you trace it?"

"Probably."

"Probably?"

Neb smiled.

"Do you want the honest answer or the engineer answer?"

"The honest answer."

Dr Stephen Buerle

"No."

Stivio closed his eyes.

"Fantastic."

Neb's expression changed.

"I can build something."

"How long?"

"Thirty minutes."

"We don't have thirty minutes."

"I can make it twenty."

Chapter Four: The Leak

The transmitter contained an encrypted navigation record.

Their entire route was there.

Every jump.

Every course correction.

Every scheduled refueling stop.

Someone had leaked their coordinates.

Dr Stephen Buerle

The crew gathered around the bridge table.

Bonji looked at each of them.

"Only four people knew this route."

Nobody moved.

Neb crossed their arms.

Stivio immediately looked suspicious.

Stivio noticed.

"Why are you looking at me?"

"Because you're new."

"I didn't leak anything."

"I didn't accuse you."

"You were thinking it."

Neb looked at KanRita.

KanRita's expression remained unreadable.

Bonji noticed.

"KanRita."

"Yes?"

Dr Stephen Buerle

"Do you have something to say?"

KanRita stared at the navigation display.

"The coordinates were transmitted before Stivio joined the crew."

Everyone looked at Neb.

Neb raised both hands.

"I didn't do it."

Bonji turned toward them.

"You modified the communications system."

"After the route was filed."

Bonji's eyes narrowed.

KanRita slowly walked toward the navigation table.

Their footsteps began.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

They stopped.

Then began again.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

Bonji watched.

"You do that when you're thinking."

KanRita nodded.

"The transmission isn't the leak."

"What?"

"It's a symptom."

They pointed toward the ship's original navigation core.

"The Courier itself transmitted the coordinates."

Bonji stared.

"Why?"

KanRita's voice became quieter.

"Because your family owes Meridian Asset Recovery money."

Bonji's face hardened.

"My grandfather paid those debts."

"Some."

KanRita pulled up an ancient contract.

"The ship was financed through a corporate asset agreement. If the account ever entered sustained default, the ship was required to transmit its position automatically."

Nobody spoke.

Bonji looked at the ship's controls.

The Starlight Courier hadn't betrayed them.

It had simply obeyed a contract.

For the first time, Bonji wondered whether they had ever truly owned the ship.

Chapter Five: The Shortcut

MAR tightened its formation.

The Courier accelerated.

Neb's modifications screamed through the engineering decks.

"You are pushing her too hard!" Stivio shouted over the intercom.

"She's fine!"

Dr Stephen Buerle

"She's making noises!"

"She always makes noises!"

"Those are different noises!"

Neb smiled.

"I know."

Bonji looked at the navigation display.

The unstable nebula waited ahead.

KanRita had spent years studying it.

There was a shortcut through the center.

A dangerous one.

Possibly suicidal.

But it was the only route MAR might not follow.

"We go through," KanRita said.

Bonji stared at them.

"You said that route killed an expedition."

"It did."

"You were responsible."

Dr Stephen Buerle

"Yes."

"Why do you want to try again?"

KanRita looked through the windshield.

"Because I was wrong once."

They turned toward Bonji.

"I'm not going to spend the rest of my life being wrong."

Bonji looked at the nebula.

Then at the approaching MAR ships.

Then at the brass compass.

They polished it once.

"Take us in."

Chapter Six: The Thing Nobody Understood

The nebula swallowed the Courier.

Every screen exploded into static.

Gravity fluctuated.

The ship dropped thousands of meters relative to the nearest gravitational reference.

Dr Stephen Buerle

Neb screamed from engineering.

"Gravity's changing!"

KanRita didn't react.

"Four seconds."

Bonji looked at them.

"Until what?"

"Until we die."

"Good to know."

The ship suddenly lurched.

Bonji grabbed the controls.

Their fingers tightened.

Then they felt it.

A vibration.

Tiny.

Almost invisible.

Bonji closed their eyes.

"Stop."

Dr Stephen Buerle

KanRita looked at them.

"What?"

"There's something wrong."

"Everything is wrong."

"No."

Bonji touched the hull.

"The ship is telling me where the gravity is moving."

KanRita stared.

Bonji began describing the vibrations.

A pulse.

A pause.

Two short tremors.

Then one long vibration.

KanRita's eyes widened.

They immediately began pacing.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

They stopped.

Then started again.

Bonji understood.

"You've seen this pattern."

KanRita nodded.

"Not in the nebula."

"Where?"

"In an ancient star chart."

KanRita pulled one of the glass slides from their navigation archive.

The old map appeared above the bridge.

The pattern matched.

The nebula wasn't chaotic.

It was oscillating.

The gravity waves were forming corridors.

Bonji could feel them.

KanRita could predict them.

For the first time, their two seemingly incompatible abilities became one navigation system.

Bonji's stubborn instinct told them where the ship needed to go.

KanRita's obsessive calculations told them when to move.

Neither could succeed alone.

Together, they had a chance.

Chapter Seven: The Chase

MAR entered the nebula behind them.

The corporate fleet trusted its computers.

The computers failed.

One cruiser disappeared into a gravitational shear.

Another lost navigation.

The remaining ships began firing blindly.

The Courier dodged between collapsing gravity waves.

Bonji ignored every warning.

"Left."

Dr Stephen Buerle

KanRita shook their head.

"Not yet."

Bonji's hands tightened.

"KanRita."

"Wait."

The hull vibrated.

Bonji felt the next wave.

"Now!"

KanRita shouted.

"Burn!"

Neb pushed the engines beyond their limits.

The Starlight Courier shot between two collapsing gravity fields.

Behind them, a MAR cruiser followed.

Too late.

The gravity corridor collapsed.

The cruiser disappeared into the storm.

Bonji looked at KanRita.

Dr Stephen Buerle

"You knew."

KanRita shook their head.

"No."

They smiled faintly.

"You felt it."

Bonji stared at them.

Then laughed.

For the first time in years, the captain wasn't thinking about debt.

They were thinking about the people sitting beside them.

Their crew.

Their family.

Chapter Eight: The Choice

The Courier emerged from the nebula.

Home was one jump away.

MAR was gone.

The pirates were gone.

Dr Stephen Buerle

The cargo was safe.

Then Stivio discovered the final problem.

One of the crate's containment seals was failing.

A tiny amount of Liquid Common Sense was leaking.

Neb stared at the container.

"If that reaches the atmosphere..."

Stivio finished the thought.

"It could contaminate an entire city."

Bonji looked at the navigation display.

They were close enough to dump the cargo into deep space.

They could survive.

The mission would fail.

Their planet would remain poor.

The crew could return alive.

Or they could continue.

Bonji looked at the others.

Neb stared at the leaking container.

Dr Stephen Buerle

KanRita stared at the stars.

Stivio stared at the emergency release.

Finally, Bonji spoke.

"We don't sacrifice millions for a delivery."

Stivio nodded.

They opened the emergency containment system.

Instead of dumping the cargo, they isolated the damaged section and transferred the substance into Neb's improvised containment device.

The ridiculous machine built from scrap and junk worked.

Barely.

But it worked.

The delivery continued.

Chapter Nine: Home

The Starlight Courier entered orbit around their homeworld three days later.

The crew watched the planet grow beneath them.

It was beautiful.

Poor.

Overcrowded.

Desperate.

But alive.

The cargo was delivered.

The first controlled samples of Liquid Common Sense began transforming their scientific institutions almost immediately.

New energy systems.

New agricultural techniques.

New medical breakthroughs.

New solutions to problems their civilization had accepted as permanent.

The planet would never be the same.

Bonji stood alone on the bridge afterward.

The brass compass rested in their palm.

For the first time, they didn't polish it.

Neb entered.

"You know we're still broke."

Bonji smiled.

"I know."

"And the ship is still falling apart."

"I know."

"And I still want to modify the jump drive."

Bonji looked at them.

"No."

Neb sighed.

"Had to try."

KanRita entered next.

They carried an ancient glass star chart.

"There is something you should see."

Bonji looked at it.

The chart showed the nebula.

But underneath it was something else.

A symbol.

The same symbol engraved on the Liquid Common Sense container.

KanRita's expression tightened.

"This predates the oldest known civilization."

Dr Stephen Buerle

Bonji stared at the symbol.

"Who made the substance?"

KanRita slowly shook their head.

"I don't know."

The ship suddenly vibrated.

Bonji froze.

Their hand tightened around the brass compass.

One faint pulse.

Then another.

Bonji looked toward the stars.

The vibration wasn't coming from the ship.

It was coming from somewhere outside.

Something was transmitting.

Something enormous.

And somehow...

It knew the Starlight Courier was listening.

END

Benjamin Lipton Jr

Assignment Write a Story

GEN108: Introduction to
Artificial Intelligence

Dr Stephen Buerle

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